

Important Idioms and Phrases

- A dark horse - Someone who unexpectedly wins a competition, someone who surprises others with their skills or talents.
- A man of straw - A man of no substance.
- Above board – legitimate, honest.
- As clear as mud - not at all clear often used sarcastically.
- At the heels - Immediately following, Soon after
- Back to the drawing board - it's time to start all over due to failure of an attempt.
- Be up to no good - To plan something bad, mischievous, etc.
- Bee in one's bonnet - Carrying an idea which constantly occupies your thoughts.
- Bite off more than you can chew - To take on a task that is way too big.
- Bite one's tongue - To struggle not to say something that you want to say.
- Black sheep (of the family) - The worst, least accepted member of a family
- Blessing in disguise - Something good that isn't recognized at first.
- Burn the midnight oil - To work late into the night, alluding to the time before electric lighting.
- Cake not worth the candle - Refers to something in which result vs. efforts are too less.
- Call it a day - To end work and go home.
- Can't judge a book by its cover - Cannot judge something primarily on appearance.
- Carrot-and-stick - use of a combination of reward and punishment to induce a desired behaviour.
- Caught between two stools - When someone finds it difficult to choose between two alternatives.
- Chance one's arm - Deciding to do something even though the chances of success are very little.
- Chase your tail -
Spending a lot of time and energy doing a lot of things but actually achieving too little.
- Costs an arm and a leg - when something is very expensive.
- Cover a lot of ground - To go through a lot of information.



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- Cross the bridge when we come to it - To deal with a problem if and when it becomes necessary, not before.
- Cut the ground from under feet - when you cut the ground from under someone's feet, when you cut you do something which weakens their position.
- Deliver the goods - Do what is expected or promised.
- Eat, sleep and breathe something - Being so enthusiastic and passionate about something that you think about it all the time.
- Face the music - To accept the (unpleasant) Consequences of what you have done.
- Far cry from - Very different from.
- Feel a bit under the weather - Feeling slightly ill.
- Fifth wheel - Useless, out of place, unnecessary.
- Fill someone's shoes - To replace someone.
- Fine-tooth comb - Examining something carefully to not miss out any details.
- Foot in the door - Small but good start with a possibility for a bright future.
- Fresh pair of eyes - A new reader, someone who hasn't seen something before.
- Get ducks in a row - Getting your things well organized.
- Get the axe - lose the job.
- Give the benefit of the doubt - Believe someone's statement, without proof.
- Go bananas - Refer to someone who behaves in a crazy way out of emotions.
- Have on the brain - Thinking or talking about it all day long.
- Hear it on the grapevine - to hear rumours about something or someone.
- Hit the nail on the head - Do or say something exactly right.
- Hit the sack / sheets / hay - To go to bed.
- In a cleft stick - If you say that a person or organization is in a cleft stick, you mean that they are in a difficult situation which will bring them problems and harm whatever they decide to do.

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- In a state of flux - If something is in a state of flux, it is constantly changing.
- In the bag - Refers to a situation when you are sure that success is sure.
- In the heat of the moment - Overwhelmed by what is happening in the moment.
- It takes two to tango - Actions or communications need more than one person.
- Jump on the bandwagon - Join a popular trend or activity.
- Just what the doctor ordered – Exactly the thing that is or was needed to help improve something or make one feel better.
- Keep a straight face - To force oneself not to laugh, even though one wants to.
- Keep his temper with the employees - refrain from being angry.
- Keep something at bay - Keep something away.
- Kick the bucket - to die
- Keep your fingers on the pulse - Being constantly aware of the most recent developments.
- Last straw - The final problem in a series of problems.
- Let sleeping dogs lie - do not disturb a situation as it is - since it would result in trouble or complications.
- Let the cat out of the bag - To share information that was previously concealed.
- Long shot - something that has a slim (small) chance of happening.
- Miss the boat - This idiom is used to say that someone missed his or her chance.
- Neck of the woods - Area or part of a country.
- No love lost between - of two people, nothing but animosity, disdain, or disrespect for one another.
- Not let grass grow under feet - Don't delay in getting something done.
- Not playing with a full deck - Someone who lacks intelligence.
- Off one's rocker - Crazy, demented, out of one's mind, in a confused or befuddled state of mind, senile.
- On the ball - When someone understands the situation well.

Important Idioms and Phrases

- Once in a blue moon - Happens very rarely.
- Picture paints a thousand words - A visual presentation is far more descriptive than words.
- Piece of cake - A job, task or other activity that is easy or simple.
- Play to the gallery - To behave in a way intended to make people admire or support you.
- Put two and two together - draw a correct inference.
- Shooting their mouth off - you talk about something that you shouldn't be, and in the process irritate people or make them extremely angry. This expression also means to talk boastfully about something.
- Sink your teeth into - doing something with a lot of energy and enthusiasm.
- Sit on the fence - to avoid taking sides in an argument or is hesitant to choose between two sides in a dispute in order to remain neutral.
- Skeleton crew - the minimum number of people needed to keep a service/office operating.
- Stand on ceremony - insist on the strict rules of formality.
- Swallow one's pride - Accepting something humiliating or embarrassing.
- Take the heat out of - to relieve the pressure on someone or something.
- The whole nine yards - Everything that is possible.
- Think on your feet - Adjusting quickly to changes and making fast decisions.
- To be above board - To be honest in any business deal.
- To cry wolf - To give false.
- To drive home - To emphasize.
- To have an axe to grind - A private end to serve.
- To hit right nail on the head - To do the right thing.
- To keep one's temper - To be in good mood.
- To leave someone in the lurch - Desert someone in his difficulties.



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- To pick holes - To criticize someone.
- To play second fiddle - To support the role and view of another person.
- To rake over the ashes - To discuss something unpleasant that has happened in the past.
- To set one's face against - To oppose with determination.
- Waiting for the cat to jump - to delay taking action until we see how events will turn out.
- When the balloon goes up - when the trouble or action begins.
- Wild goose chase - a foolish and fruitless search, futile attempt to get something unobtainable.